Chapter 4.

BACK TO THE FUTURE

As National Security Balances Globalization

Till 2014, like the rest of the world, much of India too was lulled by the soothing sounds of globalization. First came Brexit and its challenge to the European experiment. Soon thereafter was the election of Donald Trump and the articulation of *America First*. A China–US tussle, which was supposedly only tactical, became truly serious with the passage of time. Each episode enhanced the realization of the vulnerabilities that economic and technology concentrations had created. Then came the Covid pandemic, which thoroughly exposed the hollowing out of so many economies in the name of global efficiency. A new consensus began to emerge on the importance of resilient and reliable supply chains, as also on digital trust and transparency. A legacy issue, meanwhile, ground to an abrupt end with the hasty exit of American troops from Afghanistan. This was followed by the Ukraine conflict whose global impact confirmed how deeply integrated we all now are. And not least, the West Asia tinder box saw our worst fears realized with a new level of conflagration.

So, we have the revival of all the negatives of global politics that were thought only recently as anachronistic. Did we really not see it coming? Were we in denial? Perhaps some combination of both, enhanced by strong vested interests, their ability to lull the international community and a human propensity to hope for the best. All that globalization optimists were convinced was behind us has now returned with a bang. World politics is struggling with the intense interdependence of technology, finance, trade and resources coexisting with the overwhelming compulsions of security, sovereignty, privacy and values. The former pulls us towards developing closer linkages, while the latter cautions us about its vulnerable consequences. Navigating these contradictions will surely challenge all our creativity because the tensions of the present now collide with the prospects